Class 8 Social Science – Chapter 5

Universal Franchise and India’s Electoral System

NCERT • Exploring Society: India and Beyond • Part 1 • Simple English Question–Answers

इस PDF के पृष्ठ 118–138 में दिए गए अध्याय के सभी मुख्य विषयों, गतिविधियों और अंत में दिए गए 9 प्रश्नों को ध्यान में रखकर सरल अंग्रेजी में प्रश्न–उत्तर तैयार किए गए हैं। इसमें परीक्षा के लिए अतिरिक्त महत्वपूर्ण प्रश्न भी शामिल हैं।

Topic 1: Universal Adult Franchise

Q1. What is universal adult franchise?

Answer: Universal adult franchise means that every adult citizen has the right to vote, without discrimination based on caste, religion, gender, race, education or income.

Q2. What is the minimum voting age in India?

Answer: The minimum voting age in India is 18 years.

Q3. What is meant by franchise?

Answer: Franchise means the right to vote in an election. It is also called suffrage.

Q4. What is Article 326 of the Indian Constitution related to?

Answer: Article 326 provides for elections to the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies on the basis of adult suffrage, subject to the conditions laid down by the Constitution and law.

Q5. When was the voting age in India reduced from 21 to 18 years?

Answer: The voting age was reduced from 21 to 18 years in 1988.

Q6. Why is universal adult franchise important?

Answer: It gives equal voting rights to all eligible adult citizens. It allows people to choose their representatives and participate in democracy.

Q7. Could every Indian vote before Independence?

Answer: No. Before Independence, only about 13 per cent of Indians were allowed to vote. Voting rights were not universal.

Q8. Why was universal adult franchise a progressive decision in India?

Answer: In 1947, India's literacy rate was about 14 per cent and only about 8 per cent among women. Still, the Constitution makers gave voting rights to all eligible adult citizens instead of limiting voting to educated or wealthy people.

Q9. What does equality in voting mean?

Answer: It means that every eligible voter has one vote and every vote has equal value.

Q10. Why must a person register as a voter?

Answer: A person must be registered in the electoral roll of their constituency to exercise the right to vote.

Topic 2: Importance of Universal Adult Franchise

Q1. How does universal adult franchise strengthen democracy?

Answer: It allows all eligible citizens to participate in elections. It gives people an equal voice and makes elected representatives answerable to the public.

Q2. How does voting promote equality?

Answer: Every eligible voter gets one vote, irrespective of their wealth, education, caste, religion or gender.

Q3. How can voters hold elected representatives accountable?

Answer: Voters can question their representatives and vote them out in the next election if they do not work properly.

Q4. Why should women have equal voting rights?

Answer: Women are equal citizens. Equal voting rights allow them to participate in public decisions and help shape the country's future.

Q5. Why is voting both a right and a responsibility?

Answer: Voting is a right because citizens can choose their representatives. It is a responsibility because they should make informed choices and help protect democracy.

Topic 3: Ensuring Every Eligible Citizen Can Vote

Q1. Why is organising elections in India difficult?

Answer: India has a very large population, a vast area and great geographical diversity. Elections must reach people in cities, villages, mountains, forests and remote areas.

Q2. Which institution organises elections in India?

Answer: The Election Commission of India (ECI) organises elections to Parliament, State Legislative Assemblies and the offices of the President and Vice President.

Q3. How does the Election Commission help elderly voters and persons with disabilities?

Answer: It provides accessibility measures such as wheelchair assistance, ramps, braille-enabled voter cards and assistance through apps. The chapter also describes home voting facilities for eligible elderly voters and persons with disabilities in the 2024 elections.

Q4. What is postal voting?

Answer: Postal voting is a method that allows eligible voters in specified categories to cast their votes through a postal ballot instead of voting in person at a polling station.

Q5. Why are accessibility measures important?

Answer: They remove barriers to voting and help more eligible citizens participate in elections.

Q6. What are some reasons why people may not vote?

Answer: Some people may not vote because of lack of awareness, migration, distance from polling stations, work commitments, inconvenience or lack of interest.

Q7. How can voter participation be increased?

Answer: Voter awareness campaigns, accessible polling stations, accurate voter lists, convenient voting arrangements and public education can encourage more people to vote.

Topic 4: Secret Ballot and the Class Representative Election

Q1. What is a secret ballot?

Answer: A secret ballot is a voting method in which nobody else knows which candidate a voter has chosen.

Q2. Why is a secret ballot important?

Answer: It protects the privacy of voters and helps them vote freely without pressure, threats or influence.

Q3. Who were the candidates in the Class 8 election described in the chapter?

Answer: The candidates were Ahmed, Gurmat and Ravi.

Q4. What did the three candidates promise?

Answer:

- Ahmed promised to improve classroom and playground cleanliness.
- Gurmat proposed peer coaching and mutual learning.
- Ravi wanted more space for music, theatre and visual arts in the timetable.

Q5. Who was the Election Officer in the school election?

Answer: Ms. Usha was the Election Officer. She organised the election and ensured that the rules were followed fairly.

Q6. Why was a Braille ballot paper provided for Neha?

Answer: It enabled Neha to vote independently and participate equally in the election.

Q7. What were the results of the class election?

Answer: Out of 33 votes cast, one ballot was invalid. Ahmed received 8 votes, Gurmat received 12 votes and Ravi received 10 votes. Gurmat was elected Class Representative because she received the most valid votes.

Q8. What is NOTA?

Answer: NOTA stands for “None of the Above”. It allows voters to indicate that they do not support any of the listed candidates.

Q9. Does NOTA automatically cancel an election in India?

Answer: No. As explained in the chapter, NOTA does not change the result. It expresses dissatisfaction with the available candidates.

Q10. What lesson does the class election teach us?

Answer: It teaches us the importance of fair rules, secret voting, accessible ballots, transparent counting and respect for the election result.

Topic 5: The Election Commission of India (ECI)

Q1. What is the Election Commission of India?

Answer: The Election Commission of India is an independent constitutional body responsible for conducting free and fair elections in India.

Q2. When was the ECI established?

Answer: The Election Commission of India was established in 1950.

Q3. Which elections does the ECI conduct?

Answer: It conducts elections to the Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha, State Legislative Assemblies, and the offices of the President and Vice President.

Q4. When were the first general elections held in independent India?

Answer: The first general elections in independent India were held in 1951–1952.

Q5. What are the main functions of the ECI?

Answer: Its main functions are:

1. Setting election dates.
2. Registering political parties.
3. Overseeing the election process.
4. Enforcing the Model Code of Conduct.
5. Taking steps to help ensure free and fair elections.

Q6. Who is the Chief Election Commissioner?

Answer: The Chief Election Commissioner is the head of the Election Commission of India.

Q7. What is the role of a Returning Officer (RO)?

Answer: A Returning Officer is responsible for conducting an election in a constituency.

Q8. What is the role of an Electoral Registration Officer (ERO)?

Answer: An Electoral Registration Officer manages the electoral roll, or voter list, for a constituency.

Q9. What is the role of a District Election Officer?

Answer: The District Election Officer coordinates election-related work at the district level.

Q10. Who was T. N. Seshan?

Answer: T. N. Seshan became the Chief Election Commissioner in 1990. He introduced and enforced important measures to make elections fairer, including stricter rules for campaigning and monitoring election expenditure.

Topic 6: Managing the Electoral Process

Q1. Why is managing elections in India a huge task?

Answer: India has a very large number of voters and constituencies. Election officials must arrange polling stations, voting equipment, security, voter lists and counting across the country.

Q2. How many voters were eligible to vote in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, according to the chapter?

Answer: About 968 million voters were eligible to vote.

Q3. How many parliamentary constituencies were there for the 2024 Lok Sabha elections?

Answer: There were 543 parliamentary constituencies.

Q4. How many polling stations were there in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, according to the chapter?

Answer: There were over one million polling stations.

Q5. What is a constituency?

Answer: A constituency is an area whose voters elect a representative to a legislative body.

Q6. What happens at a polling station before a person votes?

Answer: The polling officials check the voter's name and identity, mark the voter's finger with indelible ink, record the required details and direct the voter to the voting machine.

Q7. What is an Electronic Voting Machine (EVM)?

Answer: An Electronic Voting Machine is a device used to record votes electronically during elections.

Q8. What is VVPAT?

Answer: VVPAT stands for Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail. It produces a paper slip that allows a voter to verify that the vote has been recorded for the chosen candidate.

Q9. Why is VVPAT useful?

Answer: It provides a paper record for verification and can help in checking votes in case of disputes or problems with the electronic system.

Q10. What is the difference between an EVM and a paper ballot?

Answer: An EVM records votes electronically, while a paper ballot records a vote on a physical ballot paper. EVMs can make vote recording and counting more efficient, while paper ballots provide a physical voting record.

Topic 7: Model Code of Conduct (MCC)

Q1. What is the Model Code of Conduct?

Answer: The Model Code of Conduct is a set of rules and guidelines that political parties, candidates and governments must follow during elections.

Q2. Why is the Model Code of Conduct important?

Answer: It helps ensure that elections are conducted fairly and peacefully and that voters are not unfairly influenced.

Q3. Can the ruling government announce new schemes to influence voters during an election?

Answer: The Model Code of Conduct restricts announcements of new schemes or projects that may influence voters during the election period.

Q4. Is giving gifts in exchange for votes allowed?

Answer: No. Influencing voters through gifts in return for votes is punishable.

Q5. Why should candidates avoid abusive language during campaigns?

Answer: Abusive language can create hostility and disturb peaceful campaigning. Candidates are expected to behave responsibly and follow election rules.

Q6. What are some examples of possible violations of the MCC?

Answer:

- Distributing gifts to influence voters.
- Using government resources for election campaigning.
- Offering money in exchange for votes.
- Using abusive or threatening language against opponents.

Q7. When was the Model Code of Conduct first adopted, according to the chapter?

Answer: It was adopted in Kerala in 1960 and circulated by the ECI to political parties during the 1962 general elections.

Topic 8: Elections to the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies

Q1. What is a general election?

Answer: A general election is an election in which representatives are elected to a legislative body, such as the Lok Sabha or a State Legislative Assembly.

Q2. What is a direct election?

Answer: A direct election is one in which eligible voters directly choose their representatives.

Q3. What is the First-Past-the-Post system?

Answer: It is an electoral system in which the candidate who receives the highest number of votes in a constituency wins, even if the candidate receives less than 50 per cent of the total votes.

Q4. What is an MP?

Answer: MP stands for Member of Parliament. An MP represents a constituency in Parliament.

Q5. What is an MLA?

Answer: MLA stands for Member of the Legislative Assembly. An MLA represents a constituency in a State Legislative Assembly.

Q6. What is the difference between an MP and an MLA?

Answer: An MP represents people at the national level in Parliament, while an MLA represents people at the state level in the State Legislative Assembly.

Q7. How is the national government formed after a Lok Sabha election?

Answer: The political party or coalition that wins a majority of Lok Sabha seats forms the national government. Its leader typically becomes the Prime Minister.

Q8. How is a state government formed?

Answer: The party or coalition that wins a majority of seats in the State Legislative Assembly forms the state government. Its leader becomes the Chief Minister.

Q9. What is a coalition government?

Answer: A coalition government is formed when two or more political parties work together to form a government.

Q10. Why is the First-Past-the-Post system easy to understand?

Answer: It is easy to understand because the candidate with the highest number of votes in a constituency wins the election.

Topic 9: Reserved Constituencies

Q1. Why are some Lok Sabha seats reserved for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes?

Answer: Reserved seats help ensure representation of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes in Parliament, as these communities have historically faced social disadvantages and discrimination.

Q2. How many Lok Sabha constituencies were reserved for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, according to the chapter?

Answer: The chapter states that 84 constituencies were reserved for Scheduled Castes and 47 for Scheduled Tribes.

Q3. Can only members of the reserved community vote in a reserved constituency?

Answer: No. All eligible voters in the constituency can vote, but only candidates belonging to the community for which the seat is reserved can contest that reserved seat.

Topic 10: Election to the Rajya Sabha

Q1. What is the Rajya Sabha?

Answer: The Rajya Sabha is the Council of States and the Upper House of the Indian Parliament.

Q2. Is the Rajya Sabha elected directly by the people?

Answer: No. It is mainly elected indirectly by elected members of the State Legislative Assemblies.

Q3. How many members of the Rajya Sabha are elected by MLAs, according to the chapter?

Answer: According to the chapter, 233 members are elected by elected MLAs.

Q4. How many Rajya Sabha members are nominated by the President?

Answer: The President nominates 12 members with special knowledge or practical experience in fields such as literature, science, art and social service.

Q5. Why is the Rajya Sabha called a Permanent House?

Answer: The Rajya Sabha is never dissolved. One-third of its members retire every two years, and new members are elected.

Q6. What is the term of a Rajya Sabha member?

Answer: A Rajya Sabha member has a term of six years.

Q7. What is an indirect election?

Answer: An indirect election is one in which elected representatives choose another representative. For example, elected MLAs choose Rajya Sabha members.

Q8. What is the single transferable vote system?

Answer: It is a voting system in which voters rank candidates according to their preferences. It is used in Rajya Sabha elections and certain other elections.

Topic 11: Election of the President of India

Q1. Is the President of India elected directly by the people?

Answer: No. The President is elected indirectly by an Electoral College.

Q2. Who forms the Electoral College for the Presidential election?

Answer: It consists of elected members of both Houses of Parliament and elected members of the Legislative Assemblies of states and the Union Territories of Delhi and Puducherry.

Q3. Which voting system is used to elect the President of India?

Answer: The single transferable vote system is used.

Q4. Why is the President elected indirectly?

Answer: The President represents the whole country. The Electoral College brings together elected representatives from the Union and the states, giving the election a wider democratic basis.

Q5. Do nominated Rajya Sabha members vote in the Presidential election?

Answer: No. Nominated members of the Rajya Sabha do not vote in the Presidential election.

Q6. Do members of State Legislative Councils vote in the Presidential election?

Answer: No. Members of Legislative Councils do not vote in the Presidential election.

Topic 12: Election of the Vice President of India

Q1. How is the Vice President of India elected?

Answer: The Vice President is elected indirectly by an Electoral College consisting of elected and nominated members of both Houses of Parliament.

Q2. Which voting system is used in the Vice-Presidential election?

Answer: The single transferable vote system is used.

Q3. What is the role of the Vice President in Parliament?

Answer: The Vice President is the Chairperson of the Rajya Sabha.

Q4. What happens if the President cannot perform their duties?

Answer: The Vice President steps in to perform the President's functions as provided by the Constitution.

Topic 13: Challenges and the Future of Indian Elections

Q1. What are the main challenges faced by India's electoral system?

Answer: The main challenges are the growing influence of money, candidates with criminal records, voter apathy and the spread of misleading information.

Q2. What is voter apathy?

Answer: Voter apathy means a lack of interest in voting or participating in elections.

Q3. Why is money power harmful to elections?

Answer: Money power can unfairly influence voters, create unequal opportunities for candidates and weaken free and fair elections.

Q4. How can voters make better choices?

Answer: Voters should learn about candidates, understand their promises, check information carefully and vote according to their judgement rather than pressure or gifts.

Q5. How can social media help elections?

Answer: Social media can spread election information, share candidates' views and encourage people to participate in democracy.

Q6. How can social media harm elections?

Answer: It can spread fake news, rumours, misleading messages and hateful content. These can confuse voters and create divisions.

Q7. What can young people do to strengthen democracy?

Answer: Young people can learn about elections, spread voter awareness, check facts before sharing information and encourage eligible citizens to vote responsibly.

Part 14: Answers to All Questions at the End of the Textbook

The following are answers to the nine questions on page 138 of your PDF.

Q1. Why is universal adult franchise important for a healthy democracy?

Answer: Universal adult franchise is important because it gives every eligible adult citizen an equal right to vote. It allows people to choose their representatives without discrimination. It also makes elected leaders accountable to the people.

Q2. What is the meaning of ‘secret ballot’? Why is this important in a democracy?

Answer: A secret ballot is a voting method in which nobody knows which candidate a voter has chosen. It protects voters from pressure, threats and influence. It helps people vote freely and honestly.

Q3. Give examples of direct and indirect elections.

Answer:

- Direct election: People directly elect members of the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies.
- Indirect election: Elected MLAs elect members of the Rajya Sabha. The President is also elected indirectly by an Electoral College.

Q4. How is the election of members to the Lok Sabha different from that to the Rajya Sabha?

Answer: Lok Sabha members are directly elected by the people from their constituencies. Rajya Sabha members are mainly elected indirectly by elected members of the State Legislative Assemblies. The President nominates 12 members to the Rajya Sabha.

Q5. What, in your view, are the advantages of the EVM over paper ballots?

Answer: EVMs can make voting and counting faster and reduce the need to print and transport large numbers of ballot papers. They can also reduce errors in counting. VVPAT provides a paper record to help voters verify their votes.

Q6. Voter turnout has been declining in some urban areas of India. What could be the reasons for this trend, and what steps can be taken to encourage more people to vote?

Answer: Voter turnout may decline because of lack of interest, migration, work commitments, long queues, inconvenient polling locations or a lack of trust in candidates.

The following steps can encourage more people to vote:

1. Conduct voter awareness campaigns.
2. Make polling stations accessible and convenient.
3. Keep voter lists accurate.
4. Explain the importance of voting.
5. Encourage young and first-time voters to participate.
6. Help eligible voters understand the voting process.

Q7. Why do you think a proportion of seats in the Lok Sabha is reserved for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes? Write a short note.

Answer: Seats are reserved for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes to ensure that these communities have representation in Parliament. They have historically faced discrimination and social disadvantages. Reservation helps their representatives raise their concerns and participate in national decision-making.

Q8. Social media is changing the way we experience elections. Is this strengthening democracy or confusing it? Discuss the benefits, challenges and future of elections in a digital age.

Answer: Social media can strengthen democracy by spreading election information, allowing candidates to communicate with voters and encouraging public discussion.

However, it can also create confusion by spreading fake news, rumours and misleading advertisements. People may be influenced by false information.

In the future, social media can help democracy if people check facts, use reliable sources and avoid sharing unverified messages. Digital tools should support informed voting rather than mislead voters.

Q9. Visit the website IndiVotes and explore the results of a parliamentary constituency election and a State Assembly election.

Answer: This is a research activity. The answer depends on the constituency and election year selected. Here is a sample format you can complete after checking the results.

Election Results Report

A. Lok Sabha Election

- Constituency: _____
- Election year: _____
- Winning candidate: _____
- Political party: _____
- Votes received: _____

B. State Legislative Assembly Election

- Constituency: _____
- Election year: _____
- Winning candidate: _____
- Political party: _____
- Votes received: _____

Conclusion: Election results show which candidates received the highest number of votes in their constituencies. They help us understand people's choices and the working of representative democracy.

Part 15: Additional Important Exam Questions

Very Short Answer Questions

Q1. What does ECI stand for?

Answer: Election Commission of India.

Q2. What does EVM stand for?

Answer: Electronic Voting Machine.

Q3. What does VVPAT stand for?

Answer: Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail.

Q4. What does NOTA stand for?

Answer: None of the Above.

Q5. What does MCC stand for?

Answer: Model Code of Conduct.

Q6. What is the full form of MP?

Answer: Member of Parliament.

Q7. What is the full form of MLA?

Answer: Member of the Legislative Assembly.

Q8. What is the minimum voting age in India?

Answer: 18 years.

Q9. What is the term of a Rajya Sabha member?

Answer: Six years.

Q10. Who is the Chairperson of the Rajya Sabha?

Answer: The Vice President of India.

Short Answer Questions

Q1. Differentiate between direct and indirect elections.

Answer: In a direct election, voters directly choose their representatives, as in a Lok Sabha election. In an indirect election, elected representatives choose another representative, as in a Rajya Sabha election.

Q2. What is the difference between the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha?

Answer: The Lok Sabha is the Lower House of Parliament, and its members are directly elected by the people. The Rajya Sabha is the Upper House, and its members are mainly elected indirectly by elected MLAs. The Lok Sabha can be dissolved, but the Rajya Sabha is a permanent house.

Q3. Explain the importance of the Election Commission of India.

Answer: The ECI organises and oversees elections. It sets election dates, registers political parties and enforces the Model Code of Conduct. It helps protect voters' rights and ensures that elections are conducted fairly.

Q4. How does the electoral system help people participate in democracy?

Answer: It allows eligible citizens to elect representatives, express their opinions through voting and hold elected leaders accountable. It also provides procedures for counting votes and deciding election results.

Q5. Why should voters be aware and responsible?

Answer: Responsible voters check facts, learn about candidates and make informed decisions. Their participation helps improve the quality of democratic government.

Long Answer Questions

Q1. Explain the complete voting process in a Lok Sabha election.

Answer: First, the voter checks their name on the electoral roll and reaches the assigned polling station. The polling officer checks the voter's identity. The voter's finger is marked with indelible ink, and the required record is completed. The voter then goes to the voting compartment and presses the button next to their chosen candidate on the EVM. A beep confirms that the vote has been recorded. The voter can also check the VVPAT slip to verify the choice. After polling closes, votes are counted according to the prescribed procedure, and the candidate with the highest number of votes in the constituency wins.

Q2. Explain the role of universal adult franchise in Indian democracy.

Answer: Universal adult franchise is a foundation of Indian democracy. It gives every eligible adult citizen an equal right to vote, regardless of caste, religion, gender, education or income. It allows citizens to choose their representatives and participate in government. It also makes elected representatives accountable to voters. By encouraging equal participation, universal adult franchise helps protect democratic values.

Q3. Describe the different types of elections in India.

Answer: India has several types of elections:

1. Lok Sabha elections: People directly elect MPs to the national Parliament.
2. State Assembly elections: People directly elect MLAs to State Legislative Assemblies.
3. Rajya Sabha elections: Elected MLAs mainly choose members indirectly.
4. Presidential election: An Electoral College elects the President indirectly.
5. Vice-Presidential election: Members of both Houses of Parliament elect the Vice President.
6. Local body elections: State Election Commissions manage elections to Panchayats and urban local bodies.

These elections allow people to participate in government at different levels.

Quick Revision: Important Facts and Dates

Fact	Answer
Minimum voting age	18 years
Voting age reduced	1988
Article related to adult suffrage	Article 326
Establishment of ECI	1950
First general elections in independent India	1951–1952
Adoption of MCC in Kerala	1960
Lok Sabha constituencies mentioned in the chapter	543
Reserved Lok Sabha seats for Scheduled Castes	84
Reserved Lok Sabha seats for Scheduled Tribes	47
Term of a Rajya Sabha member	6 years
Retirement from Rajya Sabha	One-third every two years

Exam preparation tip: Learn the definitions of universal adult franchise, secret ballot, direct and indirect elections, ECI, EVM, VVPAT, NOTA and MCC first. Then revise the differences between the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha, the election process, and the nine textbook questions.

Source: Your uploaded Chapter 5 PDF, especially pages 118–138. The illustrations on pages 124–125 explain secret voting and the class election, while pages 129–130 show the voting process, EVM/VVPAT and the Model Code of Conduct.